

ON A PAR WITH HUMANS
A cocker spaniel gets advanced medical treatment at the Max Petz hospital, New Delhi

mos. But their bodies have not evolved to handle such high loads of salt, sugar and fat," says Bengaluru-based vet Dr Vasanth Kumar. Dr Kunal also blames the proliferating dog food market. "In the past 20 years, over 50 dog food brands have mushroomed; all have ingredients that are not tested to be suitable for dogs. Sometimes, dogs are given vitamin supplements as if they are candies when they have no need for them." Dogs are also getting predisposed to a certain risk of pancreatitis, which was rare a few decades ago. "Giving very little protein to your dog but high amounts of fat or calcium causes trauma to the pancreas," says Dr Bhanu Sharma, director and cardiologist at Max Petz. Unhealthy food and the lack of exercise are causing hormonal imbalance and increased body fat, which fuels joint ailments, metabolic disease, heart and kidney issues, besides damage to the bones, liver and brain.

A REGIMEN FOR PET HEALTHCARE

But if pet diseases have grown, so has the variety of pet treatments. Market research firm Mordor Intelligence pegs the Indian pet healthcare market at $1.25 billion (Rs 10,498 crore). Statista estimates the number of pet hospitals/ polyclinics to be over 12,000 as of 2022. But the true eye-opener is the range of treatments on offer. For example, DCC Animal Hospital's new medical centre in Delhi offers telehealth services, preventive healthcare packages, surgeries from hernia repair to cystotomy, laproscopic spaying (removing ovaries) to perineal urethrostomy (enlargement of the urethral opening) and has a radiography centre and pathology labs. Balloon valvuloplasty—to open up narrowing heart valves using a catheter—and balloon-expandable cardiovascular stents are procedures being introduced for canines in India to cure increasing lifestyle-related diseases.

Earlier this year, Tata Trusts launched India's largest hospital for small companion animals like dogs and cats in Mumbai. Spread over 98,000 square feet and five floors, the 200-bed facility has separate departments for nephrology, dermatology, internal medicine, dental care, oncology and orthopaedics.

"As healthcare providers, we have to find solutions," says Dr Kunal. "So, right from CT scans, MRIs to hormonal testing and genetic biomarkers—new treatments have come up for canine healthcare. We are like paediatricians to pet parents." They, in turn, are willing to spare no expense to get the best treatment for their beloved pets (see *Canine Life Savers*), spending Rs 14,000 a year just on routine vaccinations, according to data provided by Redseer strategy consultants.